Digital Sovereignty Special Studies Project (DSSP) Europe 2030

Funding Proposal to Mercator Stiftung
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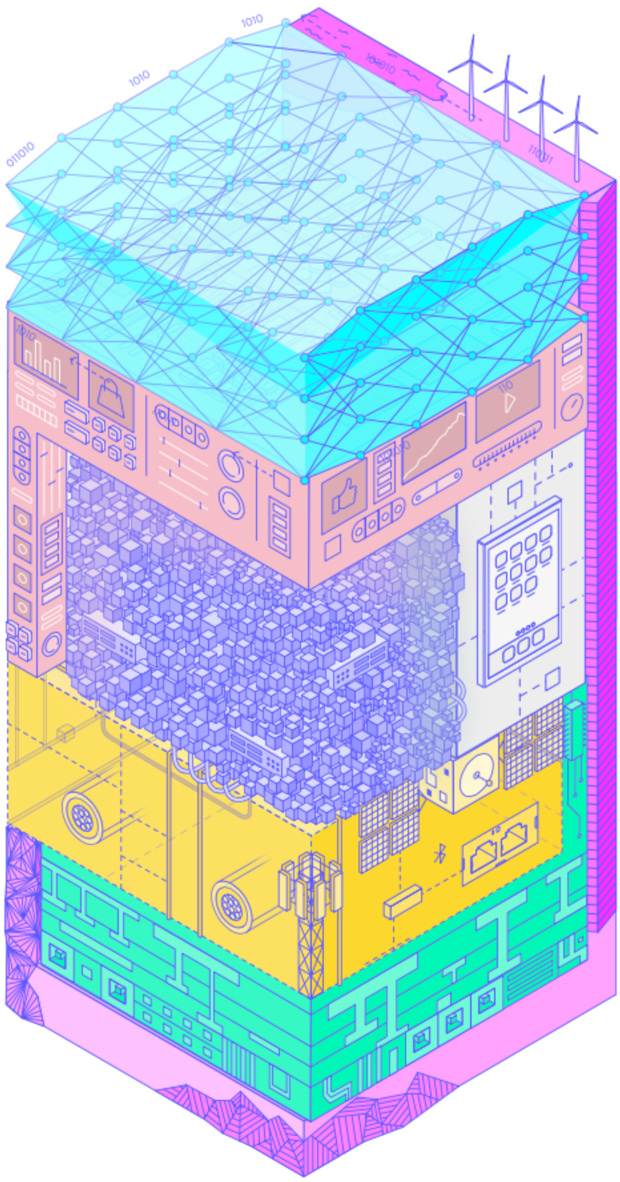
Based on: [EuroStack Strategic Framework]() created during my fellowsghip at Stiftung Mercator
Funding Request: €1,5 million over 3 years



Why Europe Needs a Special Studies Project Now

In 1956, amid escalating Cold War tensions, Nelson Rockefeller launched the **Special Studies Project** to chart a long-term national strategy for the United States. Bringing together leading thinkers from industry, academia, science, media, and the military, the initiative tackled the defining challenges of the atomic age. Its culminating publication, *Prospect for America*, became a generational blueprint for U.S. foreign and domestic policy.

Today, Europe stands at a similarly transformative crossroads.

As European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen has declared, we are engaged in a "**battle for economic and technological sovereignty**." The continent's ability to act—geopolitically, economically, and democratically—is increasingly constrained by external dependencies, fragile supply chains, and strategic asymmetries in critical technologies.

The global landscape is fragmenting:

- U.S.–China decoupling is disrupting trade, investment, and innovation flows
- Tariff and supply chain conflicts have politicized semiconductors, rare earths, and compute capacity
- Authoritarian regimes are exporting surveillance infrastructures and disinformation ecosystems
- Foundational platforms, compute infrastructure, and AI models—largely controlled by non-European actors—dominate Europe's digital economy
- The twin green and digital transitions will determine whether Europe can meet its 2050 climate, competitiveness, and welfare goals

As I argue in my recent article in *Foreign Policy*, "**Europe is at risk of becoming a digital colony**" if it fails to secure autonomy across its technology stack[1]. Dependencies in cloud infrastructure, semiconductors, data governance, and AI are no longer just industrial weaknesses—they are systemic vulnerabilities with profound implications for our democracy and economic resilience.

We must act—urgently—not only to defend European values, but to build our technological capacity, institutional agency, and democratic control. And we must do so in a way that reflects our fundamental rights and public interest.

During my Mercator Fellowship, I have worked at the forefront of Europe's digital sovereignty agenda. I have championed a vision of democratic digitization rooted in public value, rights-based governance, and long-term strategic investment. This work has culminated in the EuroStack framework—a comprehensive blueprint to build European capacity across the digital stack: from chips and cloud to compute, data, and AI.

Europe's innovation gap is stark. Over 80% of our digital infrastructure is imported. European firms contribute just 7% of global internet and software R&D. In 2024, only €7 billion went to European AI startups—compared to over €30 billion in the U.S. Meanwhile,

[1] https://foreignpolicy.com/2025/03/31/europe-digital-sovereignty-colony-trump-asml-ai-eurostack/

80% of global compute power is controlled by a few U.S. and Chinese hyperscalers, and Europe accounts for less than 4% of AI training runs[2].

But this is not the end of history. The EuroStack sets out a credible path to reverse these trends—by investing in sovereign cloud, public compute, open foundational models that run on European highly curated data sets, and next-generation AI infrastructure that reflects European values.

We are no longer alone in this vision. There is growing alignment—from major Member States like Germany and France to the European Commission and international partners. Initiatives like AI Giga Factories, Invest AI, and the Competitiveness Compass all reflect the shift toward a strategic, values-based approach to digital investment that I and others have long called for.

The time is ripe to consolidate and expand this work.

A Special Studies Project for Europe—building on the success of EuroStack—can provide the strategic and institutional backbone we need. By bringing together leading thinkers from policy, academia, industry, and civil society, we can co-design a common agenda for digital sovereignty—one that enhances Europe's capacity to act, compete, and defend democracy in the digital age.

This is the time to believe in Europe's technological future—and to make it real.

A European Response: The Digital Sovereignty Special Studies Project (DSSP)

The Rockefeller Special Studies Project: A Precedent for Strategic Foresight

In 1956, in the wake of World War II and at the dawn of the Cold War, **Nelson Rockefeller**—then President of the Rockefeller Brothers Fund—launched the **Special Studies Project** to chart a long-term strategic vision for the United States.

Directed by a young Henry Kissinger, the project convened leading thinkers from across American society: industry, universities, the military, science, journalism, labor unions, and more. Its mandate was ambitious: to define the major foreign and domestic challenges of the coming decades, and to clarify the national purpose of the United States in an era of nuclear confrontation, decolonization, and global ideological competition.

Six thematic panels were created—covering foreign policy, defense, economic policy, domestic cohesion, education, and the democratic idea. The result was a series of landmark reports, culminating in the 1961 book *Prospect for America*, which became a reference for U.S. policymakers for years to come. The Rockefeller Special Studies Project demonstrated the power of strategic foresight, cross-sectoral dialogue, and independent public interest research to shape national priorities at a moment of global transformation.

[2] https://www.euro-stack.info/docs/EuroStack_2025.pdf

Today, in the face of renewed geopolitical volatility and rapid technological disruption, this model has regained urgency and relevance.

Why It Matters Again Today: A European Response

In the United States, the legacy of the Rockefeller project has been reinterpreted through the **Special Competitive Studies Project (SCSP)**, launched in 2021 by **Eric Schmidt**, former CEO of Google. The SCSP convenes national security leaders, technology experts, and former military officials to chart a long-term strategy for U.S. leadership in AI, quantum, and defense technologies.

But the SCSP is deeply embedded in a U.S. national security worldview. It is shaped by the imperatives of great power competition, defense-industrial policy, and American primacy in dual-use technologies.

Europe faces a very different challenge—and must forge a different kind of response.

The **Digital Sovereignty Special Studies Project (DSSP)** is proposed as a European counterpart, but with a distinct public interest mission. It takes inspiration from the Rockefeller model, but grounds it in Europe's social contract, regulatory tradition, and multilateral commitment to democracy, sustainability, and openness.

DSSP puts **public purpose innovation** at the center. While acknowledging Europe's growing investment in dual-use technologies and defense readiness—especially in the wake of the Ukraine war and a shifting transatlantic order—it insists that technological sovereignty must also mean **investment in civic infrastructure, environmental goals, and democratic resilience**.

From Vision to Building

The DSSP builds directly on the **European Digital Sovereignty and EuroStack framework**[3], developed by Francesca Bria during her Mercator Stiftung Fellowship. EuroStack offers Europe's comprehensive mapping of its position across the layered digital stack—from semiconductors and cloud, to data spaces, applications, investment, and governance—and reveals the structural vulnerabilities that compromise its autonomy.

DSSP transforms that diagnosis into a coordinated platform to focus its policy implementation. It will combine strategic analysis, expert panels, challenges, and public cultural engagement to guide Europe through its most significant digital and industrial transformation since the creation of the Single Market and the Euro.

The Digital Sovereignty Special Studies Project represents a timely opportunity to help Europe move from being a regulator of technology to becoming a builder of its digital future, rooted in democratic values, public resilience, and long-term strategic capacity.

[3] https://www.euro-stack.info

EuroStack: Diagnosing Europe's Strategic Technology and Sovereignty Gaps

The **EuroStack framework**, developed by Francesca Bria during her Mercator Stiftung Fellowship, offers the most comprehensive and actionable assessment of Europe's position across the digital technology stack. It reveals not only technological dependencies but also a deeper institutional, governance, and investment vacuum—one that threatens Europe's sovereignty, competitiveness, and democratic model in an increasingly fragmented world.

EuroStack identifies six interconnected fault lines. Each is matched with a strategic recommendation that forms the foundation of the **Digital Sovereignty Special Studies Project (DSSP)** implementation agenda.

1. Critical Dependencies

Europe remains structurally reliant on non-EU actors for the foundational layers of its digital infrastructure. Advanced semiconductors, hyperscale cloud platforms, compute capacity, and proprietary AI models are controlled predominantly by companies based in the U.S. and China. This dependency undermines Europe's ability to govern its infrastructures, enforce its regulations, and protect democratic systems.

Strategic Risk: Digital extraterritoriality, foreign leverage over essential infrastructure, and monopolistic extraction.

Next Phase:
Map and Monitor Dependencies – Expand EuroStack's real-time mapping of capabilities, supply chains, and chokepoints to inform coordinated risk management and strategic planning.

2. Fragmented Strategic Capabilities

Despite having top-tier research institutions, a skilled workforce, and solid public R&D systems, Europe lacks the coordination tools to scale and deploy digital infrastructure across borders. Member States often work in silos, leading to duplication and fragmentation. There is no unified internal market for digital public goods—nor a shared strategy for deployment.

Strategic Risk: Without coordination, Europe cannot build sovereign infrastructure in key areas like cloud, AI, digital identity, or payments.

Next Phase:
Coordinate Sovereign Deployment Mechanisms – Establish a shared strategy for the rollout of key digital public infrastructure (cloud, AI, identity, payments) by aligning national initiatives through EU programs such as IPCEIs, DEP, and the Digital Decade. Promote interoperability by scaling tested models and embedding common technical and governance standards. Support the creation of cross-border infrastructure consortia—bringing together Member States, public R&D actors, and deployment agencies—to avoid duplication and accelerate continent-wide implementation.

3. The Capacity–Regulation Gap

Europe leads globally in digital regulation—with instruments such as the GDPR, the AI Act, and the Digital Services Act. However, regulation alone is not power. Without the infrastructure to implement and enforce these rules, such as sovereign cloud platforms, AI Factories, and public algorithm and data registries—Europe's legal frameworks risk becoming symbolic.

Strategic Risk: Legal mandates without supporting infrastructure lead to gaps in enforcement and technological sovereignty.

Next Phase:
Align Regulation with Industrial Policy – Match Europe's normative leadership with long-term public investment in sovereign technologies that operationalize regulatory frameworks.

4. Shifting Geostrategic Alliances

Europe has yet to fully leverage its democratic values and regulatory leadership to build strategic digital alliances**.** Countries such as India (India Stack), Brazil (Pix, Gov.br), and the African Union are constructing sovereign digital infrastructures and could become natural partners in shaping an open, rights-based digital order.

Strategic opportunity: Europe can lead in forming a global digital democracy alliance**,** offering a compelling alternative to authoritarian or extractive tech models.

Next Phase: Forge Strategic Alliances
Deepen cooperation with India, Brazil, and the African Union (but also Canada, Australia, Singapore) to co-develop interoperable, rights-based digital infrastructures grounded in open standards and mutual trust.

5. The Need for Mission-Oriented Public Infrastructure

Europe lacks large-scale, mission-driven digital infrastructure capable of supporting its strategic transitions—whether in decarbonization, healthcare, education, or mobility. Existing tools, such as IPCEIs, are often fragmented, slow, and disconnected from real-world deployment.

Strategic Risk: Without coherent, interoperable infrastructure, Europe cannot deliver its green and digital ambitions—or technological sovereignty.

Next Phase:
Launch Challenge-Based Deployment – Use the EuroStack Challenge model to deploy digital infrastructure aligned with public missions and industrial needs. These are not abstract R&D programs, but concrete, scalable deployments of sovereign technologies.

6. European Dynamism: Strategic Investment for a Sovereign Digital Future

Europe lacks a dedicated sovereign investment architecture to build and safeguard its digital future. Current instruments—such as InvestEU, NextGenEU, and InvestAI—remain fragmented, limited in scope, and insufficiently aligned to support long-term strategic objectives. New initiatives like the proposed EU Competitiveness Fund and the evolving Horizon Europe Framework aim to address this gap by streamlining instruments and increasing investment capacity. But without structural reform and greater coordination, these efforts risk falling short of the scale and coherence required.

The time has come for a new model of **European dynamism**—one that places public-interest innovation and technological sovereignty at the core of industrial strategy.

Proposal: Establish a **European Sovereign Tech Fund**, supported by a permanent **Sovereign Tech Agency**. This structure would consolidate national and EU instruments into a long-term investment platform capable of acting with strategic focus, scale, and speed.

Core Priorities for Investment:

- **Sovereign AI Infrastructure**: Public compute, open foundation models, and secure data pipelines powering essential services
- **Trusted Cloud and Compute**: European-controlled sovereign AI Cloud with transparent governance
- **Governance of Critical Layers**: Identity, data, and payments managed through public registries and consent-based infrastructures
- **Strategic Equity in Dual-Use Firms**: Invest in key sectors such as chips, quantum, defence-AI, cybersecurity, robotics, biotech, space, and clean tech

As the EU mobilizes over €800 billion for green, digital, and defence transitions—and Germany alone invests €1 trillion in infrastructure—this Fund must ensure that **public capital builds capacity**, not new dependencies.

Europe must move beyond merely regulating technologies built elsewhere. It must become a builder of sovereign, democratic infrastructures for the next technological era. This is not industrial nostalgia—it is **industrial strategy as democratic sovereignty**.

From EuroStack to DSSP: Turning Diagnosis into Action

The EuroStack report has made Europe's digital dependencies and strategic vulnerabilities visible. But insight alone is not enough. The next step is implementation.

The **Digital Sovereignty Special Studies Project (DSSP)** will transform EuroStack's analysis into action. It will serve as a strategic and civic platform to deepen research, design public-interest Challenges, mobilize alliances, and coordinate investment across borders. Together, EuroStack and DSSP form the institutional and strategic infrastructure for Europe to reclaim technological sovereignty.

Project Structure: Three High-Impact Priorities

DSSP will focus on **three strategic priorities** that are essential, feasible, and high-impact. Each will be operationalized through a dedicated **Strategic Panel**, composed of cross-sector experts from policy, technology, academia, and civil society. These Panels will define roadmaps, shape Challenge deployment, and guide investment coordination.

The goal is clear: deliver concrete, scalable infrastructure projects that strengthen Europe's capacity to act.

Priority 1: Public Digital Infrastructure – Building the Minimum Sovereign Stack interoperable at EU level

Strategic Panel 1: Sovereign Stack

This panel will define and coordinate the deployment of a **"Minimum EuroStack"**—a trusted digital infrastructure that delivers core public services through sovereign European systems. Inspired by India Stack, this European counterpart will be anchored in rights-based governance, privacy, and interoperability.

Core components include:

- The European Digital Identity Wallet (EUDI)
- Digital Euro infrastructure with electronic wallets, programmable, privacy-preserving APIs, interoperable with SEPA snatndards.
- Sectoral data spaces (e.g. health, mobility, energy), federated across Member States
- Sovereign AI Cloud platforms (e.g. StackIt, OVH)

This panel will create an investment-ready, deployment-focused roadmap—linking EU programs, Member State initiatives, and private innovation to a shared vision of sovereign infrastructure.

Priority 2: The EU AI Brain – A Connected Digital Industrial Plan

Strategic Panel 2: European AI Commons: AI Infrastructures (HPCs/AI Factories) and AI Labs serving key verticals: climate, biotech, robotics

Europe has AI talent, research labs, and regulatory leadership—but lacks a coherent, federated AI ecosystem. This panel will address the gap by building the foundations of a **European AI Commons**, helping connect compute capacity, foundational models, and data spaces into a strategic industrial network.

Focus areas:

- Dynamising the federation of Europe's AI Factories (starting from Barcelona, Bologna, Stuttgart/Julich)
- Mapping national strengths (e.g. Germany on AI for Industry and AI chips, France on frontier models, Italy on AI for manufacturing, Spain on life sciences and research)
- Supporting streamline and products based on open, trustworthy foundation models trained on highly curated European data, prioritising public interest cases.
- Ensuring public oversight and algorithm registries
- Aligning AI governance with deployment infrastructure

This panel will move Europe from fragmentation to federation, from pilot projects to scale, and from abstract regulation to sovereign deployment.

Priority 3: Digital Geoeconomics – Strategic Diplomacy for the Sovereign Stack

Strategic Panel 3: Digital Geoeconomics Strategy

Technological sovereignty must be a pillar of Europe's external strategy. This panel will position DSSP as a tool for **digital diplomacy**, supporting alliances with key partners and shaping international standards.

Core objectives:

- Co-develop public digital infrastructure with India, Brazil, the African Union, Singapore, Canada, Australia.
- Integrate DSSP into Europe's digital diplomacy agenda
- Conduct targeted analysis on regulatory divergence and tech partnerships with Turkey and China where Mercator operates.
- Support European models of AI and infrastructure governance in multilateral fora (OECD, UN, ITU).

This panel will ensure that Europe's internal infrastructure strategy also builds external alignment and global influence.

Implementation Engine: From Panels to Challenges

Each Strategic Panel will define, refine, and launch **Challenges** aligned with the EuroStack priorities. These Challenges will serve as testbeds and catalysts—turning strategy into tangible public infrastructure.

The DSSP will begin with two high-leverage Challenges, identified as the most urgent, feasible, and impactful in the EuroStack Prioritization Matrix:

Challenge 1: The Digital Identity and Payments Stack

Deploy the foundational layer of Europe's digital public infrastructure.

What it delivers:

- The EUDI Wallet: secure, user-controlled digital ID
- A programmable, privacy-preserving Digital Euro
- Consent-based data access and interoperable APIs for public services

This stack will anchor Europe's digital welfare model, enabling secure access to health, education, and mobility services—and building citizen trust in the digital transition.

Challenge 2: The AI Commons & Sovereign Compute Infrastructure

Establish sovereign control over the infrastructure powering Europe's AI future.

What it delivers:

- A federated sovereign compute layer using EuroHPC, StackIt, and AI Factories
- Open foundation models built for public-interest use
- Shared governance frameworks for algorithmic management, data access and sharing, transparency and oversight

This Challenge will ensure that Europe's AI systems reflect democratic values and remain independent of foreign-controlled infrastructure for critical use cases.

Why These Two?

These Challenges were selected based on four key criteria:

- **Strategic urgency**: Both ranked "Very High" for democratic, economic, and geopolitical relevance
- **Deployment readiness**: Backed by active EU initiatives (EUDI, ECB pilots, International data Spaces Association, EuroHPCs/AIFactories)
- **Public visibility and trust**: Citizen-facing, high-impact infrastructure
- **Scalability**: Modular design allows rollout across Member States and local contexts

Together, they form the **Minimum Viable Sovereign Stack**—a focused, implementable agenda to launch Europe's digital sovereignty.

Supporting Framework: Engagement, Coordination, and Policy Uptake

To ensure legitimacy and impact, DSSP integrates strategic foresight, public engagement, and institutional alignment:

Public Engagement

- Flagship events (e.g. re:publica, New European Bauhaus, AI Action Summit)
- A Digital Sovereignty Forum with EC, member states, industry and philanthropy.
- Media partnerships across Europe to generate debate and visibility

Institutional Integration

- Deliverables aligned with the EU Digital Decade, the next EU MMFs, national strategies, and Mercator's civic mission
- Toolkits for scaling sovereign infrastructure, procurement, and governance
- Policy briefs, roadmaps, and blueprints from each panel and challenge

Timeline and Budget Overview

Category	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	Total
Core Team & Operations	€300K	€250K	€150K	€700K
Strategic Research & Reports	€90K	€150K	€110K	€350K
Challenge Development	€55K	€100K	€95K	€250K
Public & Institutional Engagement	€50K	€30K	€70K	€150K
Communications & Outreach	€30K	€10K	€10K	€50K
Reserve & Contingency	€20K	€25K	€5K	€50K
Total	€545K	€590K	€440K	€1.5M

Strategic Partnerships and Hosting

Institutional Hosts

- **CEPS** – Brussels-based lead on EU digital policy and coordination, with Mercator-aligned networks
- **ECFR** – Geopolitical and diplomatic strategy

Supporting Ecosystem

- European Commission (DG CNECT, DG RTD, DG GROW, DG EEAS)
- EuroHPC, EIB, InvestEU, EIC, national innovation agencies (e.g. SPRIND, Bpifrance)
- Bertelsmann Stiftung, UCL's IIPP, CEPS, SciencePo

This consortium ensures that DSSP is both grounded in public interest values and embedded within Europe's institutional and policy ecosystem.

Why Mercator Stiftung? Why Now?

Mercator Stiftung's mission—to strengthen democracy, sustainability, and open society—is deeply aligned with DSSP's goals. The project proposal is a follow up of Francesca bria's fellowship at Stiftung Mercator where she developed the EuroStack framewrk as a European Alternative for Digital Sovereignty. By supporting DSSP, Mercator will:

- Help Europe build—not just regulate—critical digital infrastructure aligned with European values and fondamental rights.
- Translate values into real institutions and services
- Shape a uniquely European model of digital sovereignty with global relevance

At a moment of geopolitical upheaval and technological transformation, DSSP is a timely, credible, and impactful project that will leave a lasting legacy.